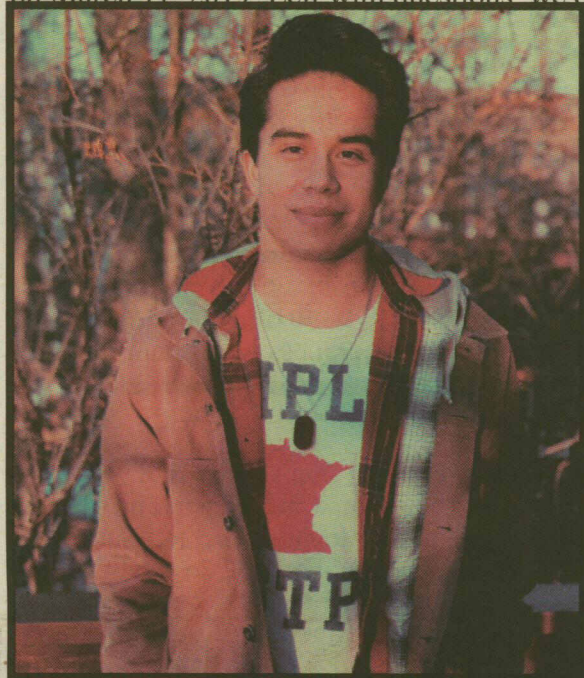


In Transition: St. Kate's Implements New Trans and Non-Binary Acceptance Policy

by Addison Cross

St. Catherine University is undergoing a period of transition. No pun intended. Physical changes to the university like campus integration have been paralleled by institutional changes such as the publication of the Transgender and Non-Binary Acceptance Policy on December 1, 2018. The policy was quietly added to the "Student Non-Academic Policies" section of the St. Kate's catalog, and has received no announcement through official university channels. The Wheel published a report on the implementation of the Trans and Non-Binary Acceptance Policy on March 11, 2019. Left with questions, we dove deeper into



Student Activist Pono Asunción.

the genesis of the Trans and Non-Binary Acceptance policy, its limitations, and what it means to students.

Associate Vice President of Admissions Cory Piper-Hauswirth provided initial information on the policy, sharing that it is "something we've been needing for a number of years that we've now put into an official policy." Much of the con-

tent pertains to the admissions process so that prospective students are aware of St. Kate's criterion for acceptance. "Being a single-gender college, the College for Women is permitted under Title IX to set our own admission policies," Piper-Hauswirth said. "Our practice has been to accept students based on self-reported sex. The official policy makes it clear that we accept students based on gender identity."

So, what does the new Trans and Non-Binary Acceptance Policy mean for students? The policy begins: "To provide documentation and clarity with the current practices for transgender and non-binary students who would like to apply for admission to St. Catherine University." It then details that the College for Adults and Graduate College will continue to admit students of any gender identity, while the College for Women admits all students who identify as women. The statement also affirms St. Kate's commitment to fostering gender diversity: "We recognize St. Catherine University's rich and vibrant history of educating people of all marginalized genders, as well as our duty as an institution to acknowledge and celebrate their contributions to our university."

Students have voiced concerns on administrative transparency surrounding the policy as well as its declared preservation of gendered language. "The fact that we haven't heard anything from President Roloff makes me feel like we are working within the limits of what higher powers have said is okay and nothing beyond that. Are we just doing the bare minimum so that trans and non-binary students don't make too many waves?"

According to Piper-Hauswirth, work on this policy began about five years ago when students and administrators recognized a need for language around the acceptance of trans and non-binary students to St. Kate's. The policy started moving forward in 2017, with the hiring of Pat Pratt-Cook, Senior Vice President for Human Resources, Equity, and Inclusion. According to Pratt-Cook, the movement toward formal inclusion of trans and non-binary students at St. Kate's had been brewing for several years.

Much of this activism remained within the realm of students. In 2015, St. Kate's alum Charlie Zieke developed a curriculum for faculty and staff surrounding transgender issues, language, and inclusion. Kapona Asunción, Women and International Development Major, '19, a major voice for the rights of trans and non-binary students at St. Kate's today, expressed frustration that there was little institutional record of Zieke's work.

In 2018, the LGBTQIA+ Equity and Inclusion working group, comprised of students, faculty, and staff was formed. The initial objective of the group was to draft a policy regarding the admission of trans and non-binary students, but it has also endeavored to approach broader issues affecting the LGBTQ community at St. Kate's.

The group began looking at the language used by other "single gender institutions" around acceptance of non-binary and trans students. The Transgender and Non-Binary Acceptance policy that they drafted includes careful language around St. Kate's identity as a women's college. Some students expressed disappointment at the unwillingness of administration to depart from the gender binary in drafting the Trans and Non-Binary Acceptance Policy. Asunción, a student representative to the working group, links St. Kate's historical advocacy for marginalized genders with our Catholic identity, though his ideal version of the policy is slightly different from what was published. In his version, the gendered language was removed, and our tradition of education people of all marginalized genders was emphasized.

However it is not always easy to align St. Kate's historical dedication to social justice with the needs of the student body today. Asunción says that "when students advocate for social justice, we're often told, 'we can't do that, we're a Catholic university.' But, I'm like we're a Catholic university because of Catholic social teaching and our mission of social justice, that's the part of our Catholic identity that we most embrace."

While many agree that this policy is a long time coming, it might feel like a jarring adjustment for some faculty, staff, and administrators. Many feminists that got their start in the Second Wave and have dedicated much of their lives to advocating for gendered language, often for the specific purpose of including women. However, Asunción highlights how this language can be damaging for some students.

From a social justice perspective, Asunción argues that St. Kate's should be a place for all marginalized genders; cisgender women, transgender women, transgender men, and non-binary students: "You have so many trans and non-binary students here who are not women, who do not identify as women, and you're just completely erasing them."

As evidenced by the curriculum created by Zieke in 2015, education on issues affecting trans and non-binary students at St. Kate's has been a burden placed primarily if not exclusively on students. An imperfect correlation can be drawn between resources provided for students of color and trans and non-binary students at St. Kate's. Although students of color continue to bear a huge amount of the weight of education on race and ethnicity, the office of Multicultural and International Programs and Services is an example of an institutional initiative to provide programming focused on issues affecting students of color. No such resource exists for trans and non-binary students at St. Kate's.

Much of the lack of understanding on the needs of trans and non-binary students comes from the institutional perception that trans and non-binary students are new to St. Kate's. "Some administrators use the excuse of, 'this is such new language, we need you to educate us on this.' My response is, educate yourself! There are so many resources out there. Saying 'be patient in the grander context of a social movement, and a movement for liberation, and a movement for equity is the worst thing you can say," said Asunción.

"We need spaces and educational resources on campus about and for queer and trans students, especially queer and trans students of color that are facing other interlocking systems of oppression."

-Pono Asunción.

Although controversial and lacking university-wide dissemination, the Trans and Non-Binary Acceptance Policy seems to be cognisant of its own progressiveness and potential mutability. The last line of the policy states; "In taking an inclusive approach to fulfilling this mission – one that reflects the University's identity and vision to be an institution that values diversity, equity and inclusion as being essential to excellence – St. Catherine University acknowledges that there is an evolving understanding of gender that increasingly goes beyond the traditional binary."